Entering Freemasonry, and especially the ceremony of Initiation, bombards the new member's senses with a huge amount of new information.

From being asked to adjust their dress prior to the ceremony, through their admission, being asked to repeat words offered in a series of prompts and the sights they see when the blindfold is removed, may leave them feeling vulnerable, anxious and confused. By definition, it is a new and unique experience, one that will outside of most people's comfort zone.

The ceremony itself is an example of experiential learning. We learn by taking part. It stimulates different emotions in different people and by doing so it leaves a lasting impression. Little wonder that many have said, "Initiation is one of the most memorable experiences in my life."

However, experiential learning is most effective when it is followed by a period of reflection and then by our own attempts to interpret and understand what has happened.

This thread addresses how we can help the new member process their experience and develop an early understanding of what they have joined.

WHY IS EARLY INFORMATION SO IMPORTANT?

- When we are exposed to something new, our brain tries to make sense of it by drawing on previous information and experiences along with the new.
- Other than the briefing you will have previously offered (see "Briefing the candidate for Initiation"), you have little control over how a new member manages this process.
- Therefore, it is important that you offer them some appropriate information and support very soon after the ceremony, starting from when the ceremony has concluded.
- Without this, the new member may develop an inaccurate or unhelpful interpretation that takes time for others to recognise, let alone clarify.

GUIDANCE FOR LODGE MEMBERS

- In recent years, attempts to provide early information have resulted in additional letters, booklets and presentations being given to the Initiate at the end of the ceremony itself.
- These have increased the amount of new information an Initiate receives at a point when they are experiencing a range of emotions.
- Some new members have reported there being "too much at once" and wanting a chance to ask questions, engage and check their understanding.
- A different approach is for the Initiate's Personal Mentor to have some time with the new member immediately after the ceremony and for additional materials to be presented at the festive board or privately at its conclusion.
- Other Lodge members and visitors can then concentrate on welcoming the new member.

GUIDANCE FOR PERSONAL MENTORS

- Immediately after the ceremony of Initiation, take five to ten minutes alone with the new member to check their reaction to the experience, address any initial questions or concerns and reassure them that it will take them a long time to process the experience and understand what happened during the ceremony.
- Offer them a copy of "Simple explanation of the Initiation ceremony" and of the "Charge after Initiation" and explain that he can share these with their wife / partner and immediate family.
- Arrange an informal meeting with the new Freemason within a week or so of their Initiation to:
  - discuss what happened during their Initiation and what they need to know for the immediate future.
  - practise with them the sign of the degree, and any firing undertaken at the Festive Board.
  - address any questions that they may have at this point.
- Ideally this meeting will be face-to-face. However, if arranging this is impractical or it introduces an unhelpful delay, it could be online.
- See "Stewardship" for further guidance on supporting a new member.

INFORMATION USEFUL TO A NEW MEMBER

- The following are among the important topics that are useful to discuss with a new member over time, during mentoring sessions and Lodges of Instruction.
- Some of the following information will be available in locally produced resources aimed at the new member. However, it is important that they have the opportunity to discuss these with their Personal Mentor.
- It is important to cover the ground at the pace and in the order that suits them, rather than overburden them with too much information at once.
- It is best to provide the information in response to their questions, always being prepared for what they might wish to discuss.
- It is also important that the information provided is current, accurate and does not impose one member's personal views on an impressionable new member with their own needs and interests.

1. The organisation of the Lodge and duties of the Lodge officers. *(Introducing the new member to those officers at the next Lodge meeting will accelerate their sense of belonging.)*
2. A schematic layout of the Lodge Room and the seating positions of the officers.
3. The names of Lodge members, their wives or partners and their contact details.
4. A symbolic explanation of the ceremony taken most recently.
5. The ritual for the ceremony taken most recently, if available and if copyright allows.
6. The correct manner of giving signs, tokens and words for that ceremony.
7. The nature of the "secrets" of Freemasonry:
   a) as no more than the means to demonstrate a Freemason's qualifications to be present in a Lodge open in a certain degree or to be admitted to another degree.
   b) for use only in an open Lodge and not outside.
8. Leaving the Lodge during a ceremony that they are not yet qualified to attend.
9. The traditional language of the ritual and its use to convey the aims, ideals and traditions of Freemasonry within a Lodge meeting.
10. The use of today's language to explain our experience of Freemasonry in a modern and relevant context.

11. The function and content of the Lodge summons.
12. Basic etiquette in Freemasonry.
13. Titles and ranks, addressing others, preambles in Lodge and at the Festive Board.
14. The Festive Board, its structure, practices and traditions.
15. Firing at the Festive Board, history and variations.
16. Lodge rehearsals and Lodges of Instruction, their value and importance.
17. The questions leading to the next degree and the answers that he must give beforehand.
18. Learning ritual; tips and techniques, an appropriate piece to start with, being ready to deliver ritual.
19. The words for the Opening and Closing Hymns used, as well as other songs used in the meeting or at the Festive Board.
20. Inviting Guests and the responsibilities involved.
21. Booking to attend meetings, the need for submitting apologies and the consequences of late responses.
22. Visiting other Lodges; booking in, paying, what to expect and what will be expected of them.
23. Respecting the differences between Lodges, their ritual and other practices.
24. Applying the principles of Freemasonry to our everyday lives. Reference to the Charge after Initiation, which spells out the way in which we should live our lives, may help.
25. Managing commitments; their first responsibility should always be to their family, secondly to their employment, and (only) thirdly to their commitments in Freemasonry.
26. The relationship between the Craft and Royal Arch within pure Antient Freemasonry, the relationship of the other Orders and maintaining a commitment to one's Mother Lodge.

Note: The names used to refer to the Lodge's meeting place and the after-proceedings differ from Province to Province. For the sake of simplicity, they are referred to in the Members' Pathway as the Lodge Room and the Festive Board, respectively. Similarly, for ease of reading all references to Provinces should be taken to apply equally to Metropolitan and District Grand Lodges.